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ENGL 6910
December 13, 2024

To Dissimulate a Lack: Technomascularity and Simulation in *MGS2*

Near the end of *Metal Gear Solid 2: Sons of Liberty*, the player-character and protagonist, Raiden, is captured by the titular terrorist group, The Sons of Liberty, and tortured by their leader, and Raiden's godfather, Solidus Snake. This torture sequence begins with the player embodied in Raiden's first-person camera, looking up at a group of overhead lights with a blue-haze filtering their vision; this shot acts as a parallel to the first game, *Metal Gear Solid*, wherein its player-character, Solid Snake, is captured and imprisoned in exactly the same device as Raiden, giving the player the same first-person perspective, except for the blue-tint. This parallel to *MGS* is one of many since Raiden's whole mission is itself revealed to be a trial of the S3 Plan, at first named the "Solid Snake Simulation." The Solid Snake Simulation is described as a military training tool constructed using Solid Snake's combat data extracted from the Shadow Moses Incident (the events of *MGS*) that can be used to generate a soldier in his image. Revolver Ocelot, one of the series' primary antagonists, who also appears during the torture sequence in *MGS*, says to Raiden, after Raiden asks where they are, "Why inside Arsenal Gear, of course. Actually, we're also inside the memory of Shadow Moses," (Kojima, 2023). Yet despite the parallels to the *MGS* combat data or memory, there is one major inconsistency in this scene: in *MGS*, Snake is wearing pants, and in *MGS2*, Raiden is stripped completely naked.

Raiden's nudity could be explained diegetically through the fact that he wears a "Skull Suit," a full-body electrofiber suit that monitors the damage inflicted to different body parts and automatically regulates them through a feedback system. Raiden, effectively, doesn't have to worry about the "nitty-gritty" of what to do when he's been shot or wounded, rendering the

wounds themselves somewhat abstract or virtual. His equipment reflects him in the way that Raiden himself, at least until the end of the game, is believed to have only undergone VR military training, without any actual time in the field; the S3 plan is his first “real” mission. When discussing the differences between VR and field exercises, Snake asks Raiden, “You don’t get injured in VR, do you?” and Raiden defensively responds that even the pain is simulated, “The only difference is that it isn’t actually happening,” (Kojima, 2023). The fact that it “isn’t actually happening,” seems to describe the mechanic of damage in this game, as well as many other action games, fairly accurately. For Raiden, through the technology of the Skull Suit, pain is only the simulation of pain, not the real effects that might occur from wounding, wherein all he and the player need to worry about is collecting rations to heal their abstract health bar.

The generic simplicity of this health mechanic is in sharp contrast to the more complicated wound system of the next game in the series, *Metal Gear Solid 3: Snake Eater*. *MGS3* takes place in 1964, and its mechanics reflect those conditions: it replaces the ever present and abstract minimap of the first two games, which displayed all enemy locations as well as their lines-of-sight, with a simpler battery powered sonar, as well as requiring the player to utilize a collection of first-aid supplies to treat a variety of ailments and parts of the body, from lodged bullets to food-poisoning. For example, to treat a knife wound, the player must enter the “heal” menu and apply (in no specific order): a disinfectant, a styptic to stop the bleeding, a suture kit to close the wound, and a bandage. The player-character in *MGS3*, Big-Boss, would of course have had to deal with these wounds without much support during an espionage mission in 1964. However, the historical presence of these mechanics reinforce the lack of mechanical complexity necessary in Raiden’s actual, diegetic mission, where his internals are monitored and managed for him through a combination of the Skull-Suit and nanomachine technology. Raiden is

functionally still experiencing only the simulation of pain because the wounds lack an actual presence that he needs to deal with.

Once Raiden and the player are set free from the imprisoning device, the first thing Raiden does is cover his crotch. Non-diegetically, this makes sense, as the developers would have to model and display Raiden's penis otherwise if he *had* to be naked under the Skull-Suit. However, this presents a potentially more impactful diegetic problem, wherein Raiden is more worried about his penis being seen than being ready to fight, so much that he covers himself even during his attack animations. This isn't the first time Raiden's penis has operated as a plot device in the game either: when Raiden first meets the President of the U.S. while trying to rescue him, the President tries to confirm Raiden's identity by reaching between his legs, and says, "You're... a man... ?" (Kojima, 2023). The President's surprise is noticeable, calling into question Raiden's ability to pass as a man, which is in turn, his masculinity. According to Derek Burrill, "In the same sense that masculinity is a product of specific practices (some bodily, some social) that require an actor and audience (and some type of "script"), masculinity can also be said to be performative," (21). Masculinity can be considered performative inasmuch as it successfully appears to be masculine, and in this case, Raiden's performance fails.

The idea of masculinity being composed of the signs of masculinity brings to mind Baudrillard's concept of a pure simulacrum, detached from any referent: "It is no longer a question of imitation, nor duplication, nor even parody. It is a question of substituting the signs of the real for the real," (2). Masculinity is understood through the signs that constitute it, and those signs are dictated by the performance of masculinity, which is made-up of those signs. This sort of self-referential equation is also part of Burrill's understanding of how masculinity is produced: "let us imagine that the complex of social relations that is masculinity stems from the

body in practice, the body in performance, the body which constantly (re)produces its own ontology,” (21). This could be described as ontoformation wherein the performance of being (masculine) produces its own script recursively.

In the case of Raiden’s failed masculine identification, he’s often noted to lack these masculine signifiers that are part and parcel of Snake’s action-hero archetype, often described as “a younger, less masculine, and more vulnerable hero,” (Higgin, 253). Snake, on the other hand, is a hypermasculine, blockbuster action hero; Snake, and Snake’s cover-name in *MGS2*, Pliskin, are even taken straight from John Carpenter’s film, *Escape from New York*, whose protagonist is named Snake Pliskin and shares numerous physical similarities with the protagonist of *MGS3* Big-Boss, whose DNA was used to clone Snake. Here, Snake’s DNA diegetically comes from the gritty, realistic and ideal soldier of *MGS3*, yet, at the same time, metatextually from Snake Pliskin, who carries similar signs of masculinity as Big-Boss. However, these signs are themselves notably without a referent as, “the masculinity that manifests itself in games,” like the DNA of Snake, “is already a type of simulation of a referent (warrior myths, hero worship, intrigue, espionage, etc.) masculinity that is itself not ‘real,’” (Burrill, 16). The simulacrum of masculinity is made manifest in Snake, yet Raiden, physically unrelated to this body of masculinity, lacks hyperreal masculinity and is better understood as a *technomale*, “intimately linked with the expert gamer,”:

Instead the subjects form a pact with their work/machines/computers. This pact is the fulcrum upon which this masculinity balances its obsessive self-interests and impulsive external showmanship...Thus, technology as object and idea serves as a kind of ideological brace for the tenuous masculinity of the technomale (Burrill, 18).

The technomale, a masculine subject, is asocially bound to technology as a space to perform masculine fantasies of mastery and control; as Newman and Vanderhoef describe, “Computer technology is equated with the masculine because of the specialized knowledge and expertise needed to operate it,” (495). Raiden’s masculinity isn’t performed through the usual, physical signs of masculinity, but through his use of state of the art military technology and supposed mastery of espionage acquired through virtual training.

However, the performative nature of masculinity, seen specifically in technomale behavior as the mastery of and conjoinment with technology, is noted by Burrill to be

constantly unstable and in need of “proving.” Freud’s notion of “castration anxiety” illustrates how this proving is a continuing process. Thus, the body is the site that the subject must (re)produce to achieve a sense of placement within the order of masculinity (21).

The instability of performative masculinity is notably linked to the need to prove the presence of the phallus, wherein the technomale “uses technology to assuage his anxieties,” establishing the technology itself as a simulation of the phallus and thus masculinity (21). But the simulation of a phallus in some way points to the idea that the phallus itself isn’t present, and in the case of technomales and computer users, they are “also positioned as emasculated, even feminine men with soft bodies due to too much time spent immobile before screens,” (Newman and Vanderhoef, 495). Raiden, a militaristic technomale, is emblematic of this emasculated position and its simulation of masculinity through technological prowess.

This brings us back to Raiden’s anxiety about his penis, or rather, his model’s lack of one. By cupping his hands over his crotch, Raiden dissimulates the lack of a penis, simulating its presence and establishing himself within the masculine simulacrum. To Baudrillard,

dissimulation is to “pretend not to have what one has,” and simulation is to “feign what one doesn’t have,” (3). By negating the lack of his penis, Raiden assuages his masculine anxieties. Raiden can be thought to be a “real man” in *MGS2* if only because he has a penis, as seen during his encounter with the President; but by extension, this simulated penis acts a microcosm of masculinity itself, wherein the penis is the ultimate verification of the simulacrum which defines itself ontoformatively. These other performances however, are just other forms of the simulated penis, the simulation of the signs of masculinity. The subjectivity of a technomale is one that seeks to perform these signs through their pact with technology, which operates very much like Raiden’s Skull-Suit, virtualizing their experience and dissimulating their lack of masculine signs. And without the cathected technology, they are left symbolically castrated, like Raiden’s nude, neutered frame.

As noted previously, the concept of a technomale is closely related to the idea of hyper-masculine gaming, or, “hardcore gamers.” The type of games favored by this “hardcore” community can be characterized by “complex mechanics, a tendency towards photorealistic visuals, and an emphasis on action and shooting,” (Newman and Vanderhoef, 497). To really break down these generic conventions, the concept of “action” functions as a good starting point. What constitutes action in a video-game? According to Aki Järvinen, action is necessarily a response to the “recognition of something significant in the game in its present state, followed by the player’s appraisal of the situation and what to do,” (87-8). This falls closely in line with Cardona et al.’s model of the player feedback loop, wherein the player interprets feedback in order to formulate goals and enact them through mechanics (10). Action, then, in the context of video-games, could be considered as the mechanical response to feedback and goal formation. This enactment of mechanics is performed via what Gregerson and Grodal call primitive actions

or P-actions, for short; “moving the index finger (to pull a trigger) is a primitive action, whereas discharging a firearm is an action,” (70). The P-action is translated into code and simulated by mechanical feedback in the form of a game action (G-action), such as Raiden firing a gun on screen. This connection of physical movement to simulated action operates as the fulcrum on which players can embody and interact with game worlds, much like the way in which technomascularity is embodied through technological performance.

With a clearer understanding of how action functions as a part of the interface of a video game, let us now see how the concepts of P and G-actions figure into the action-packed aesthetics of “hardcore” games. These kinds of games are described as “intensely performative,” by Thomas Apperly, in as much as they “will often require the player to engage in extreme nontrivial actions...The abilities possessed by the avatar of the player must be activated by a technical performance by the player,” (15-6). The intensely performative nature of “extreme” or “hardcore” games can then be understood clearly as the need to overcome difficult obstacles, which according to Dominic Arsenault, are usually a matter of “sensori-motor skills and real time play,” (295). This definition can also be understood through the genre’s reliance on having the player *synchronize* with the game; synchronization being a ludological goal focused on spatio-temporal alignment, (Cardona et al. 3). The goal of synchronization, and the difficulty that comes with it in the context of “hardcore” games seem to be core factors in the ability to simulate physical embodiment in a game-world. According to Gregerson and Grodal,

Interactive media activates aspects of [physical] embodiment: audiovisual data stimulates eyes and ears to simulate a time-space—a simulated world (SW)—and a series of interfaces map actions in order to integrate the player with a SW in an interactive feedback loop, with resulting emotions that reflect the interaction. The

interfaces provide motor links to a SW and may, to a limited extent, provide tactile aspects of interaction (in its active, but not in its passive patient, aspect) (65).

The sensori-motor link provided by the interface is naturally the line between P-actions and G-actions, and the player is provided access to this world through a simulated space-time in the form of feedback. In the case of games within the “hardcore” action genre, which rely heavily on spatio-temporal synchronicity or precise P-inputs, performative embodiment in the virtual space-time becomes a *necessity* to complete the non-trivial and complex difficulties found in these games.

In *MGS2*, the player’s success revolves almost entirely around the performance of spatio-temporal synchronicity: in order to traverse the map of the Big-Shell, the location occupied for most of the game, the player’s best course of action is usually to stay out of sight. The player succeeds in this process by first observing the feedback provided by their mini-map, as well as the two different camera modes, third and first-person, to identify the location of enemy guards as well as their view-cones, which depict their lines of sight. If the player is caught inside of these view-cones and engaged with, especially in the early game when Raiden lacks sophisticated weaponry, it will very quickly lead to them being swarmed with guards and likely killed. In order to avoid this, the player must maneuver around the guards spatially, while understanding the role time plays in their patterned movements and patrol routes. Naturally, the combat of the game functions similarly: for instance, if the player gets too close to an enemy prepared to attack without attacking them first, the enemy will knock the player to the ground, rendering them briefly immobile. The list goes on. These spatio-temporal mechanics are notably the same as the game *Metal Gear Solid: VR Missions*, which is, in the game’s diegesis, the

software based on the Shadow Moses Incident that Raiden was trained on, in which the only difference from reality is the fact that the game isn't actually happening. In the case of MGS2's player, as well as in many other action games, the high-stakes spatio-temporal alignment and precision required by the game acts as a sort of extension of their embodiment. Burrill describes this as a "'suturing' of player onto character, or avatar," wherein movement and activity produce spatial embodiment (46). And given the limited embodiment of most P-actions, "they rely very much on the *consequences of actions* relayed through audiovisual feedback for their embodied effects," (70). Through the spatio-temporal complexity of the game's mechanics, that if done poorly, often lead to severe consequences, P-actions, in action games, are almost dissimulated while they perform and simulate embodiment through the feedback of synchronous G-actions.

Technomascularity, in both of these cases, is able to perform as a "truly" masculine subject through a spatio-temporal synchronicity with the simulated feedback of masculine G-actions which, in the moment, take priority and dissimulate the lack inherent in P-actions. This need for technological performance is necessarily integral to the way in which the technomale simulates their phallus, likely making it, in part, the draw towards hyper-masculine action games. *MGS2* is even seemingly aware of the intense performativity at heart in the play and simulation of masculinity in action games. For example, shortly after escaping from his imprisonment, nude and in need of his Skull-Suit, Raiden is called by his commander, the Colonel, who's later revealed to be an A.I. fabricated by the Patriots, a cabal of autocrats who've turned themselves into an A.I. called George Washington (GW for short) and set up the very S3 Plan that Raiden and the player immersed in. As the Colonel's status as a simulation is revealed, he says in reference to Raiden's mission, "This is a type of role playing game. The point is that you play out your part and I expect you to turn in a perfect performance!" (Kojima, 2023). Raiden's first

“real” mission, the S3 Plan, is very much a role playing game, in the sense that this mission requires him to play the role of Snake in a simulation of the events of *MGS*. As noted previously, Solid Snake is a clone of Big-Boss, who is himself a copy of the hyper-masculine signs that made up Snake Pliskin. Snake’s data, which sets the foundation for the simulacrum of masculinity, is used to construct a simulation of masculinity in order to generate Snake through Raiden’s embodied, action-intensive performance.

However, during the torture scene, Raiden’s status as only a technomale with a lack of previous field training is actually revealed to be the dissimulation of battle experience; his performance anxiety was simulated. Solidus Snake, a more perfect clone of Big-Boss, recognizes Raiden as a prodigious child soldier that he had fathered and named during the civil war in Liberia. After examining him, Solidus realizes that Raiden has had his memories erased by the Patriots: “High-concentration of cerebral implants...Have they altered your memory, too?” (Kojima, 2023). Raiden’s subjectivity here begins to slip off into the space of pure simulation, capable of being manipulated and rewritten at will. Tanner Higgin argues that “Raiden’s body is informatic to the extent that its biological basis can be exploited, modified, managed, and reworked as needed to fuse with and execute the simulation,” (261). Through the use of nanomachine technology in his body, alongside his Skull-Suit, Raiden becomes a subject *designed* for the S3 Plan. His insecurity that’s thrust upon him by the S3 Plan is assuaged by his reliance on technology, which enforces a hegemonic structure. By simulating a lack in Raiden, they exploit it and use him as a lab rat.

But why does Raiden still feel the need to cover this simulated lack if his memories have returned to him? Well, after Raiden discovers that the Colonel is one of the Patriot’s puppets, Otacon, one of Snake’s allies discovers that,

The Colonel probably isn't GW per se. GW was most likely stimulating cortical activity in the dormant part of your brain through signal manipulation of your own nanomachines. The Colonel is in part your own creation, cobbled together from expectation and experience, (Kojima, 2023).

This is also true of Raiden's simulated insecurities, manifested by the same technology as the Colonel. Raiden's insecurities become hyperreal in the sense that the simulation creates real effects in his performance and his experience of reality. Even though the insecurity itself is a product of a simulation, in much the same way that technomascularity as a whole is a product of the larger simulacrum of masculinity, his simulated subjectivity is still experienced and performed as reality. This calls back to Burrill's concept of ontoformation, wherein the performance of being becomes being. Though Raiden's lack was simulated and contradictory to his real experience, the equally real experience of that simulated lack partially rewrote his own self-image as a simulacrum.

The potential effects of the simulation on the player also come into question here, as Raiden and the player are both placed inside of the S3 Plan. Of course, playing through MGS2 won't equip the player with the ability to *actually* perform as Solid Snake, but according to Higgin, even actual military simulation training is more focused on constructing memories that can be recalled for later use (263). He further elaborates on this simulated construction of memory in relation to the military-entertainment complex as a whole after discussing the use of the game *America's Army* as recruitment software:

However, such a subject formation is in no way limited to games explicitly created for military recruitment. Instead, many different video games can be seen

as not only creating certain kinds of memories but significantly shaping opinions and perceptions of warfare (264).

For Higgin, the real effect of the hyper-masculine hardcore games isn't that it necessarily trains soldiers, but creates real, potentially positive experiences of warfare from simulated experience that can shape the subject's opinion of war. During Snake and Raiden's conversation about VR training, Snake mentions that it's an effective tool to "remove you from the fear that goes with battle situations," to which Raiden responds, "So you're saying that VR training is some kind of mind control," (Kojima, 2023). Hardcore games that simulate intense masculine embodiment and permit technomales a dissimulation of their lack, can take advantage of that lack in the same way the Patriots took advantage of Raiden, potentially leading to a form of hegemonic masculinity.

However, this technomasculine lack is itself also a product of simulation, or rather, a direct effect of the simulacrum of masculinity which interpellates masculine subjects. Burrill notes, in reference to David Savran's work on masculinity, that:

Thus, no base or original masculinity (much less a biologically based one) can exist in Savran's mode, in which the subject is produced in the performance through the historical material performative texts he inspects. Savran implied then "that masculinity is not an achieved state but a process; a trial through which one passes," (25).

Masculinity, understandably, has no bottom, and through the engagement with masculine scripts, the male finds himself in a continual process of proving the presence of his phallus within the social order of the simulacrum, necessarily always lacking the "real" masculinity. This continual process of proving falls closely in line with the general loop of action games, wherein the performance of synchronization is measured through death as a fail state. Death in this case,

could be seen as masculine failure, or in the case of *MGS2* as the “Mission Failed” screen, which really means the failure to perform like Snake within the confines of S3.

The simulacrum of masculinity, built up from the signs that constitute masculinity, much like S3 being built up of the signs and data that constitute Snake, could be understood as a sort of possibility space of the body. According to Merleau Ponty:

What counts for the orientation of the spectacle is not my body, such as it in fact exists, as a thing in objective space, but rather my body as a system of possible actions, a virtual body whose phenomenal “place” is defined by its task and by its situation (260).

The body in this case, is not necessarily a “real” thing, but rather a construction of an organized system that’s dependent upon circumstance and goals, much like how feedback organizes and orients the player for action and embodiment within virtual space. In the case of masculinity, as a simulacrum and hyperreal truth, in order to pass as masculine, the subject must perform within the confines of possible actions and signs of masculinity, which may or may not be conscious. In short, the masculine body is arranged by the “context” of masculinity, a kind of set of G-actions, wherein the “content” of masculinity is performed and filled in by the subject, through their P-actions.

This difference between “context” and “content” is itself essential to the Patriot’s overall plan, and the GW A.I. that determines this plan; during a conversation with Raiden, GW, speaking through an A.I. puppet of Raiden’s mission analyst and lover, Rosemary, states that, “What we propose to do is not to control content, but to create context,” (Kojima, 2023). In the digital information age, the Patriots view the influx of dis and misinformation as a threat to global progress and consensus reality. Information silos and isolated discourse communities

destroy the potential for a single, unified social truth. The Patriots seek to combat this by managing the flow of information and maintaining “truth,” and thus we arrive at the true meaning of the S3 Plan: the Selection for Societal Sanity, a simulation that can totally reorganize a subject’s reality. The S3 Plan as the Solid Snake Simulation was only one of many potential simulations the Patriots could generate, and they only chose it to stress test their possibilities for organizing subjectivity. According to Higgin, the “simulation accepts subjects into its envelope and then, through the subjectivity-shaping process of gaming, creates the ideal subject,” (264). The game itself becomes a possibility space of the militarized, masculine simulacrum, potentially altering the subject’s understanding of reality. By controlling the “context” of the code, the limits of G-actions and potentialities of the simulation itself, they constrain Raiden and the player’s performance within the simulated world of masculine subjectivity. To maintain the hyperreality of masculinity, the simulation generates masculine “content” through play and performance.

However, the true S3 Plan is still only a simulacrum, based on the model of a past social reality, with little claim as to what “truly” sits at the bottom of the mass of digital information. Raiden says it best himself when he asks A.I. Rose, “you think you’re qualified to decide what’s necessary and what’s not?” (Kojima, 2023). Yet the GW insists that they are, and that Raiden in fact, “lacks the qualifications to exercise free will,” and that his sense of self “serves as nothing more than a mask to cover [his] own being,” and “endow [him] with some sense of strength,” (Kojima, 2023). Their critiques towards his sense of self aren’t necessarily inaccurate, as we’ve seen through the insecure dissimulation of his lack, yet the Patriots fail to realize that they’re much the same way. Their insistence upon the identity of a true consensus reality is in a lot of ways, simply a reaction to digital culture and a means to maintain order and hierarchy through simulation. Baudrillard notes that despite the fact that Borges’ fable of the map and the territory

is unusable in the era of simulation, only “the allegory of the Empire, perhaps, remains. Because it is with this same imperialism that present-day simulators attempt to make the real, all of the real, coincide with their models of simulation,” (1-2). But in the era of simulation, the principle of reality itself has disappeared; subjects are stuck in a world of infinite reorganization and hyperreality. This logic is reflected in Arsenal Gear’s map, which instead of depicting the “real” space Raiden and the player are in, depicts an illustration of the repeating World Turtle which is on and surrounded by an Ouroboros. In response to this world of simulation, the GW tries to reign control of this never-ending spiral and to define its context, the context of “real” things like masculinity, and to dissimulate the inherent lack of reality; but with nothing real to stand on, to ease its own anxieties and maintain the status quo, the Empire is forced to cover its own lack.

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